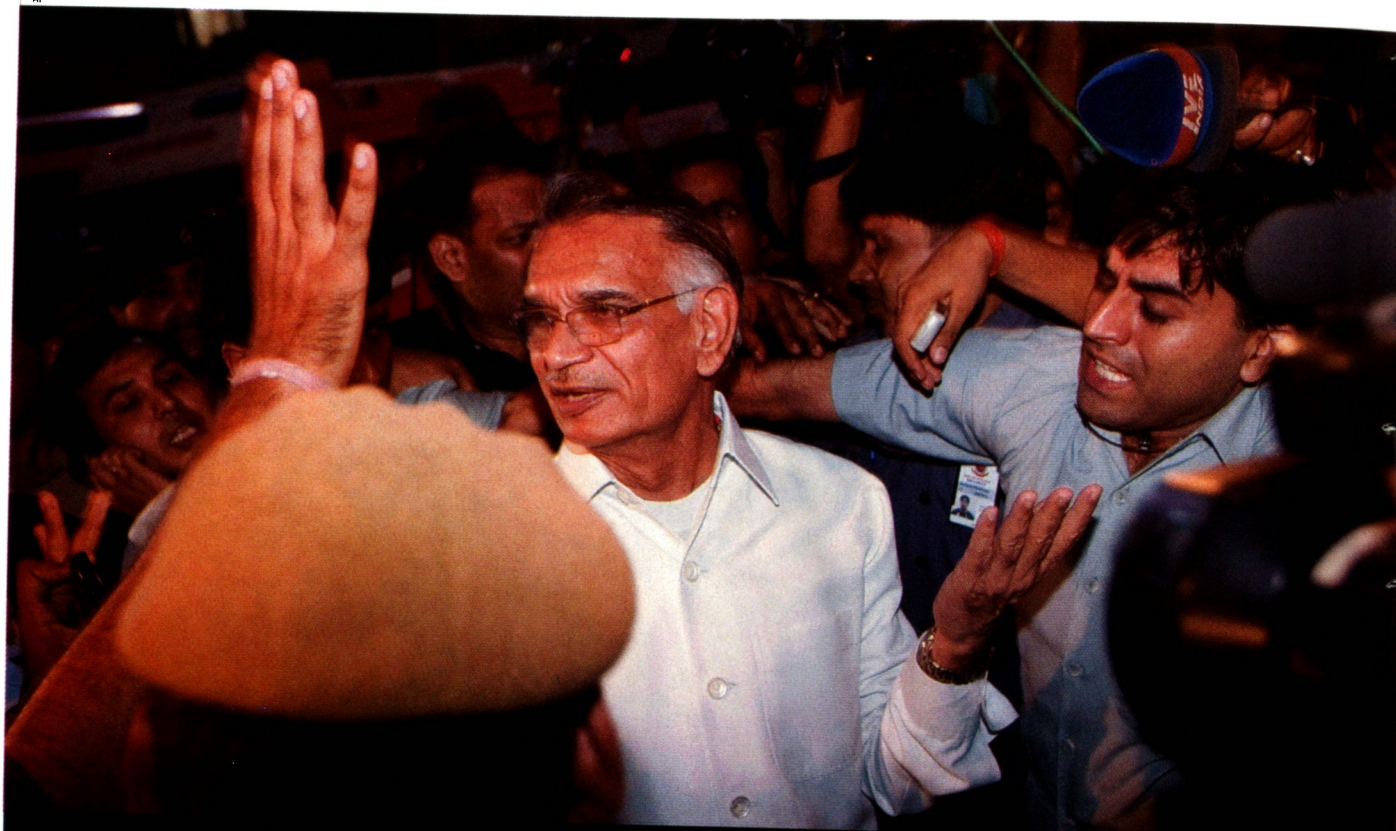


AP

**SHIVRAJ
PATIL****DRESSED TO KILL**

Patil's biggest weakness—his lack of political base and clout within the party—is his strongest asset

The home minister has had a harrowing weekend indeed. Ridiculed for paying more attention to his wardrobe than the nation's security, Shivraj Patil immediately went into a corrective overdrive. Home Ministry officials dialed the media and clarified that the reports claiming that the minister changed three clothes in two hours were wrong. He had only changed three outfits in five hours! The poor man was being misrepresented, they said. And how. At a time when the BJP has made internal security its main election plank for E-2009, the incompetent and effete image of the home minister has become a liability for the Congress. Unfortunately, to remove him now would be a tacit admission of failure—not just of Patil's ability to keep the citizens of India safe but also of Sonia Gandhi's choice of leadership. After all, it was at her initiative that Patil was rehabilitated in Manmohan's council of ministers even after he lost the Lok Sabha elections. Later, when the country needed an inspiring candidate to replace A.P.J. Abdul Kalam at Rashtrapati Bhavan, once again, Sonia's first choice was Shivraj Patil.

Despite the criticism from UPA allies and the

Opposition, not to mention Congressmen, Sonia is still hesitant to axe her Man Friday. "Whom do we replace him with?" asked a worried general secretary. It is somewhat ironic that Patil's biggest weakness—his lack of political base and clout within the party—became his strongest asset when Sonia looked for a candidate for North Block. There were many effective men for the job, beginning with Pranab Mukherjee but she did not want someone who could challenge the prime minister. Traditionally the home minister is usually the number two man in the government, whether it was Sardar Patel in Jawaharlal Nehru's time, S.B. Chavan in Narasimha Rao's tenure and more recently L.K. Advani during A.B. Vajpayee's rule. To that extent, Sonia's plan has worked. While all these other names emerged as pretenders to the throne, no one regards Patil as the second in command. Whenever Manmohan goes abroad, he leaves a note with the cabinet secretary that gives Pranab Mukherjee the authority to take all important decisions in case of a national emergency. While Manmohan is going by seniority of the individuals, this has merely added to the